

Asia Quantitative Strategy

India Quant Strategy: Time to add more India exposure - The opportunity set widens



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We remain neutral on India. However, with the [momentum \(tech/AI\) trade under-pressure led by record high valuations, earnings expectations and crowding](#); we believe the case for India is improving. While the recovery remains selective rather than broad-based, the combination of cheaper valuations, emerging earnings support for large-caps and potential foreign flow normalization creates a more constructive outlook. We prefer large-caps over SMIDs and recommend adding momentum names while maintaining some high-quality defensive exposure; especially stocks where earnings momentum is improving.

India valuations have reset. Pockets of earnings support emerging: MSCI India has fallen from peak valuations of 23.2x fwd. PE in Q424 to 18.6x fwd. ie. below 10yr avg, after three years. India's premium to EM has fallen to 10yr levels on fwd. PE and at COVID lows on PB. Most sectors are now trading at or below 10yr average, with Financials and Tech trading near COVID-era PEs, creating a much better entry point. While an average stock is still seeing higher pace of downgrades, there are early signs of earnings recovery led by large-caps and certain sectors like Materials and Consumer. The long-term earnings growth expectations have also fallen to 10.6% which is way below historical averages; indicating positive returns over the next 12m.

Return of foreign investor interest and the growing opportunity set: We believe the opportunity set has increased in India, even for global investors; who have been using India as a funding source for the regional AI/tech trade, resulting in record outflows of -US\$29bn. This has started to come back in July (+US\$1.8bn) and even active GEM funds have reduced their UW to -2.1% from -2.7%. Some sectors such as Staples, Tech, Energy, Real Estate present a trade due to record low crowding while above-average dispersion in Utilities, Real Estate, Tech and Materials is presenting active stock picking opportunities. Financials and Tech are extremely cheap while Materials and Consumer could find support from earnings recovery.

Factor positioning: We have been positive on quality since the beginning of the year and the style has been the best in 1H26, down -0.4% vs. market down -4.5%. India quality comes at a price but given earnings upgrades are intact and geopolitical uncertainty remains high, we believe keeping this defensive exposure on is prudent. Since April, we added more risk in India through momentum stocks, which are up 15% since then. We believe momentum rally in India is likely to strengthen from here given near record low valuations and inflection on earnings/crowding cycle. We also prefer large-cap exposure vs. SMIDs given very attractive valuations and better earnings revisions. Across the styles, we focus on stocks where earnings momentum trends have been showing an improvement in the last 6 months.

We show our preferred screens in Exhibit 17-Exhibit 18. For our Asia, China, Korea screens, see our updated deck - [Asia Quant Strategy Deck](#).

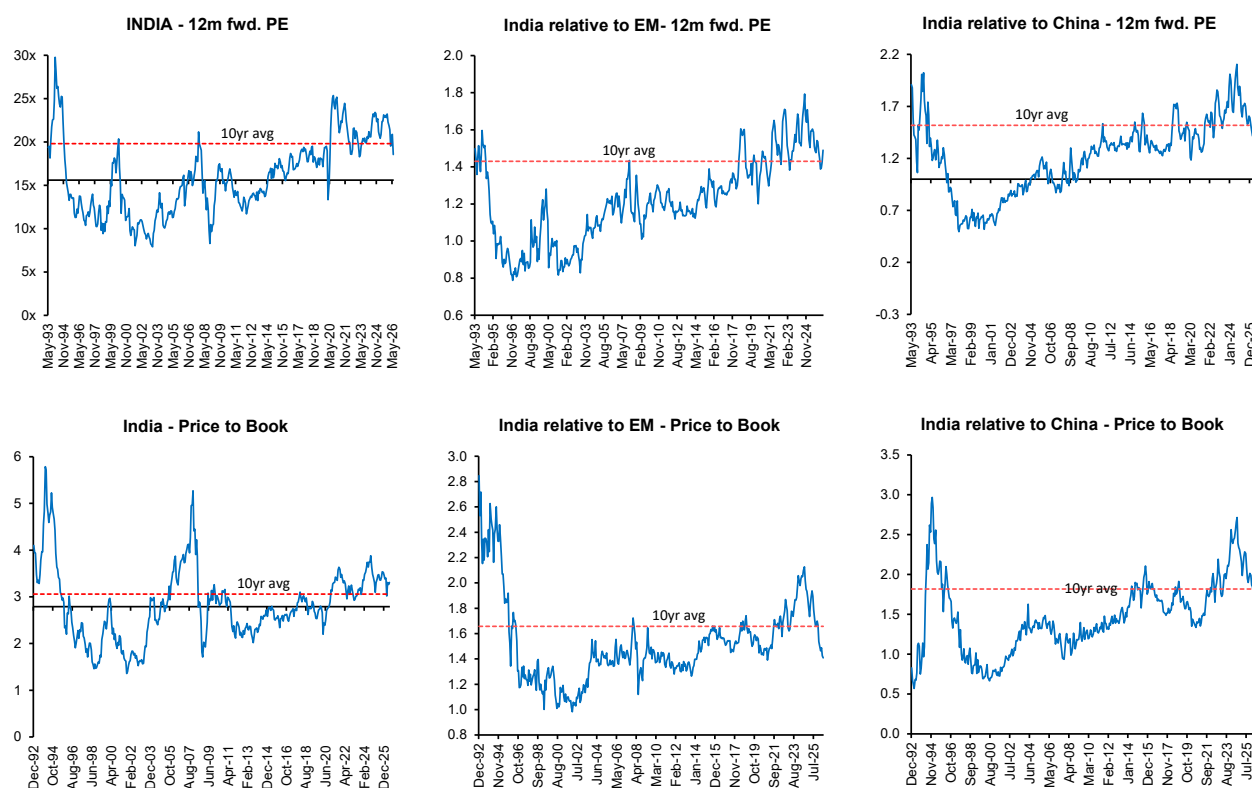
DETAILS

Indian market has been under pressure since Q4'25 and in the first half of 2026, MSCI India is down -10% in dollar terms while KR was up 112% and TW 64%. Since June, as expected, momentum trend has started seeing a reversal in turn improving sentiment towards the anti-momentum/anti-AI market ie. India. Since April, we added more risk back in India, and we believe there are ample opportunities for investors to look at. We discuss them below.

INDIA IS NOW CHEAP - FINANCIALS AND TECH NEAR COVID LOW MULTIPLES

Indian market has de-rated to below 10yr average valuations after 3yrs; now trading at 18.6x fwd. PE ie. -0.7SD below 10yr avg. On book-value it is still slightly above average levels at 3.3x PB. Relative to EM, valuations seem to have bottomed on 12m fwd. PE while on PB the relative valuation has now dropped to COVID lows. Most sectors are now trading at or below 10yr average, with Financials (-1.9SD) and Tech (-1.5SD) being the cheapest sectors trading at COVID level valuations. Healthcare, Industrial, and Utilities are relatively expensive, trading above 10yr average, but within +1SD. Staples, Financials, Technology, Energy are trading at COVID lows even on PB. Hence, Financials, Technology, Energy are quite attractively valued now. (Exhibit 1-Exhibit 3)

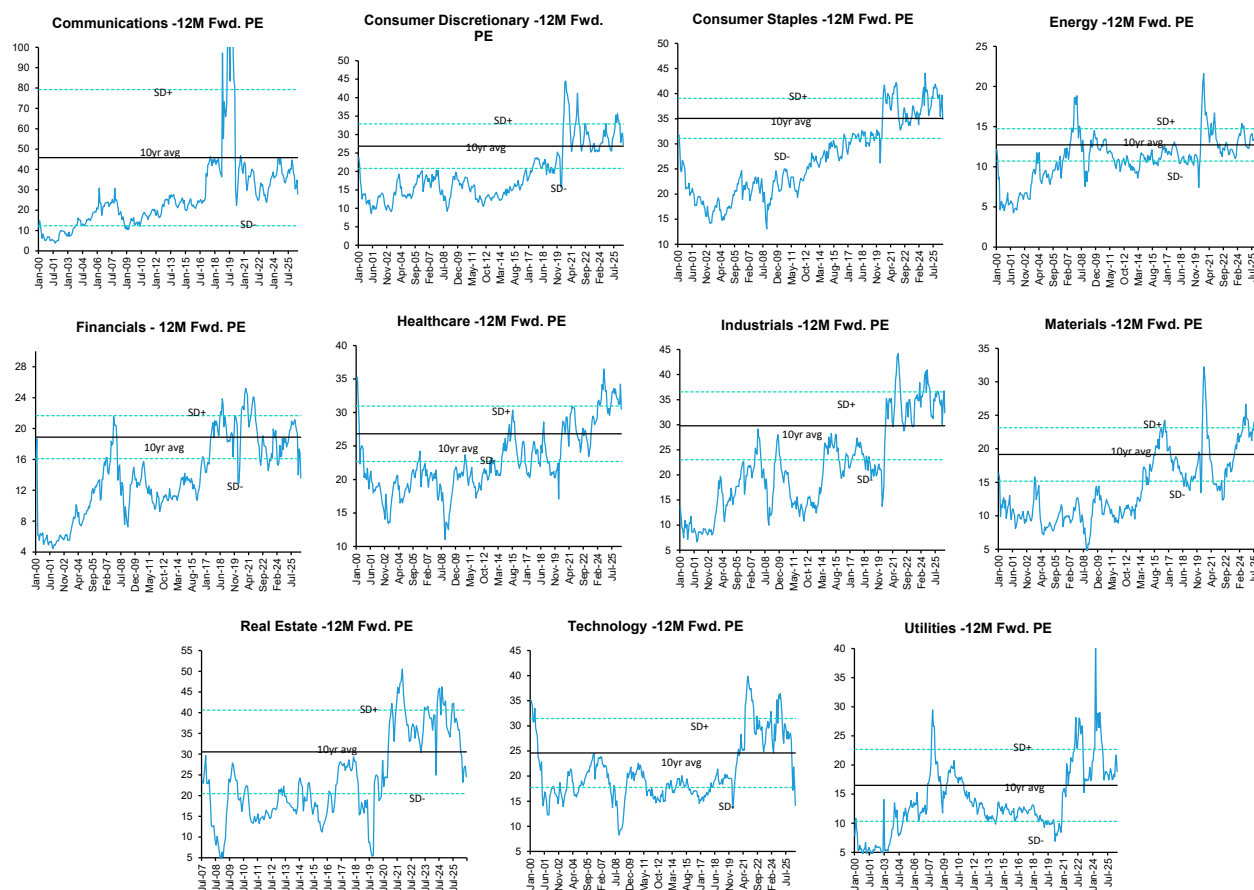
EXHIBIT 1: India valuations are now cheap both on absolute and relative basis, which trade at 18.6x on fwd PE and at 3.3x on PB. Relative to EM, India's PB has fallen near COVID lows



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

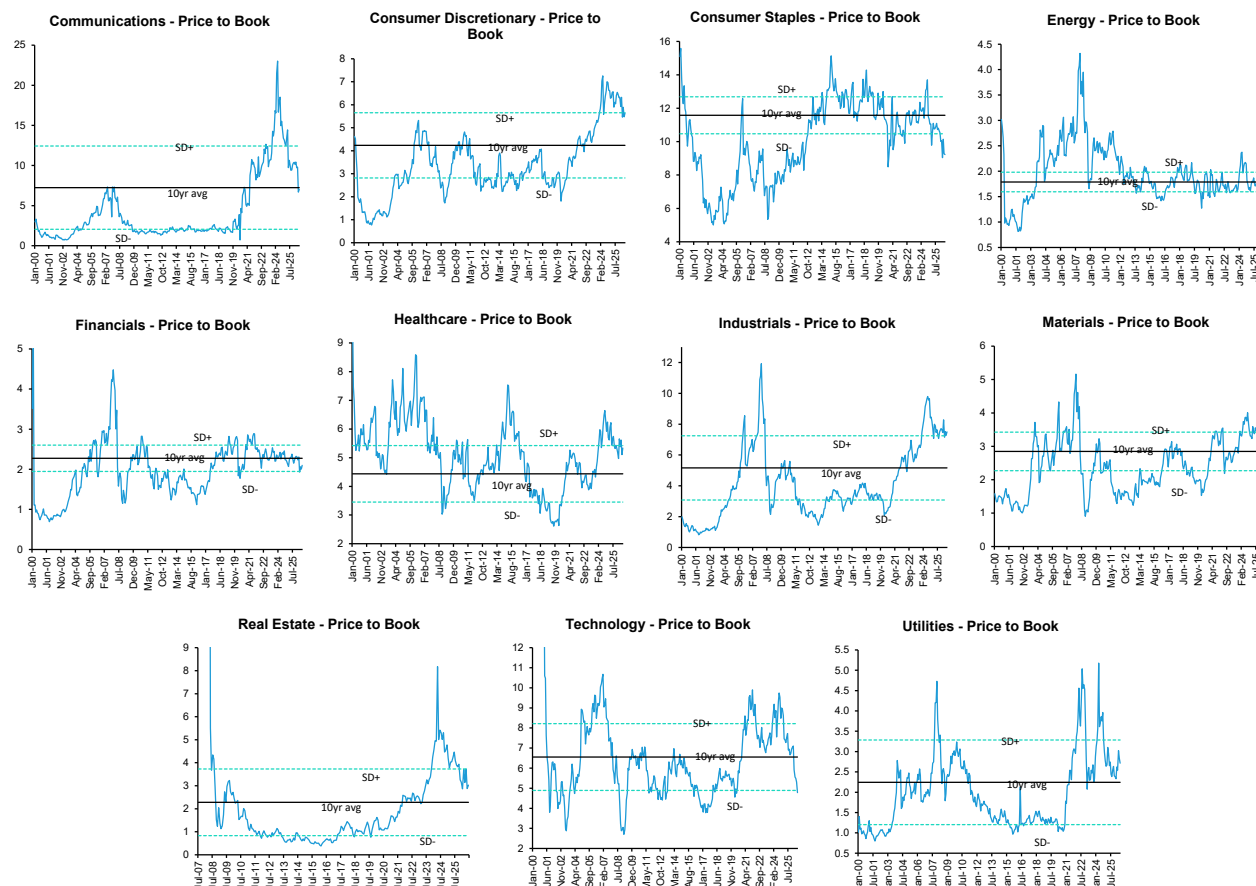
Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 2: Except Healthcare/Industrials/Utilities all sectors are trading at or below average. Fin/Tech now at COVID lows



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

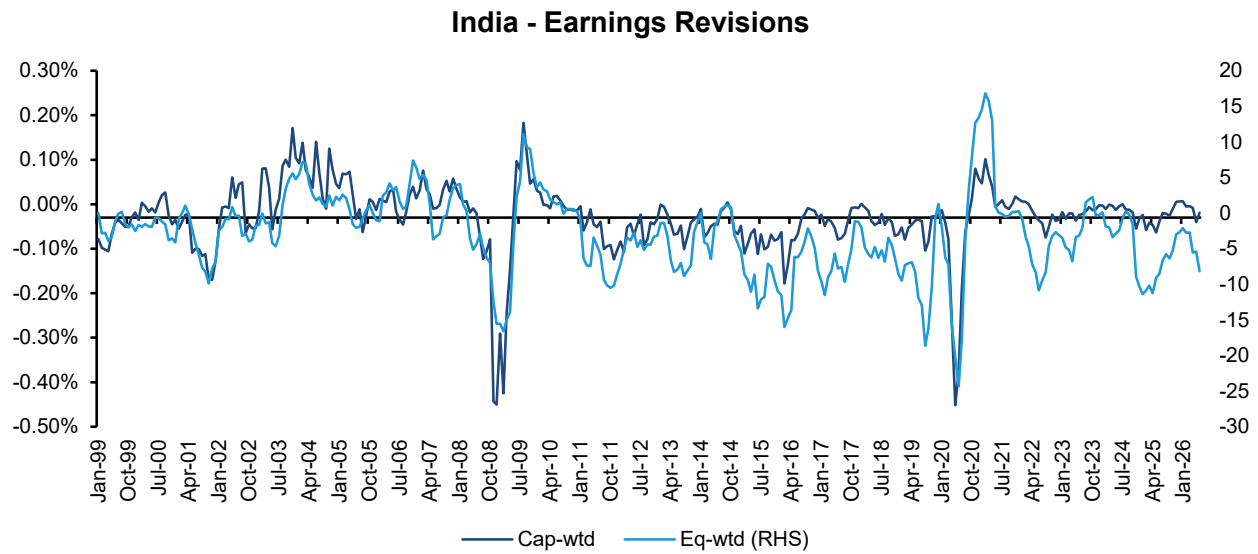
EXHIBIT 3: On Price to Book - Staples, Financials, Technology, Energy are trading near COVID lowsData as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

INDIA SEEING EARLY SIGNS OF EARNINGS RECOVERY LED BY LARGE-CAPS AND MATERIALS/ CONSUMER

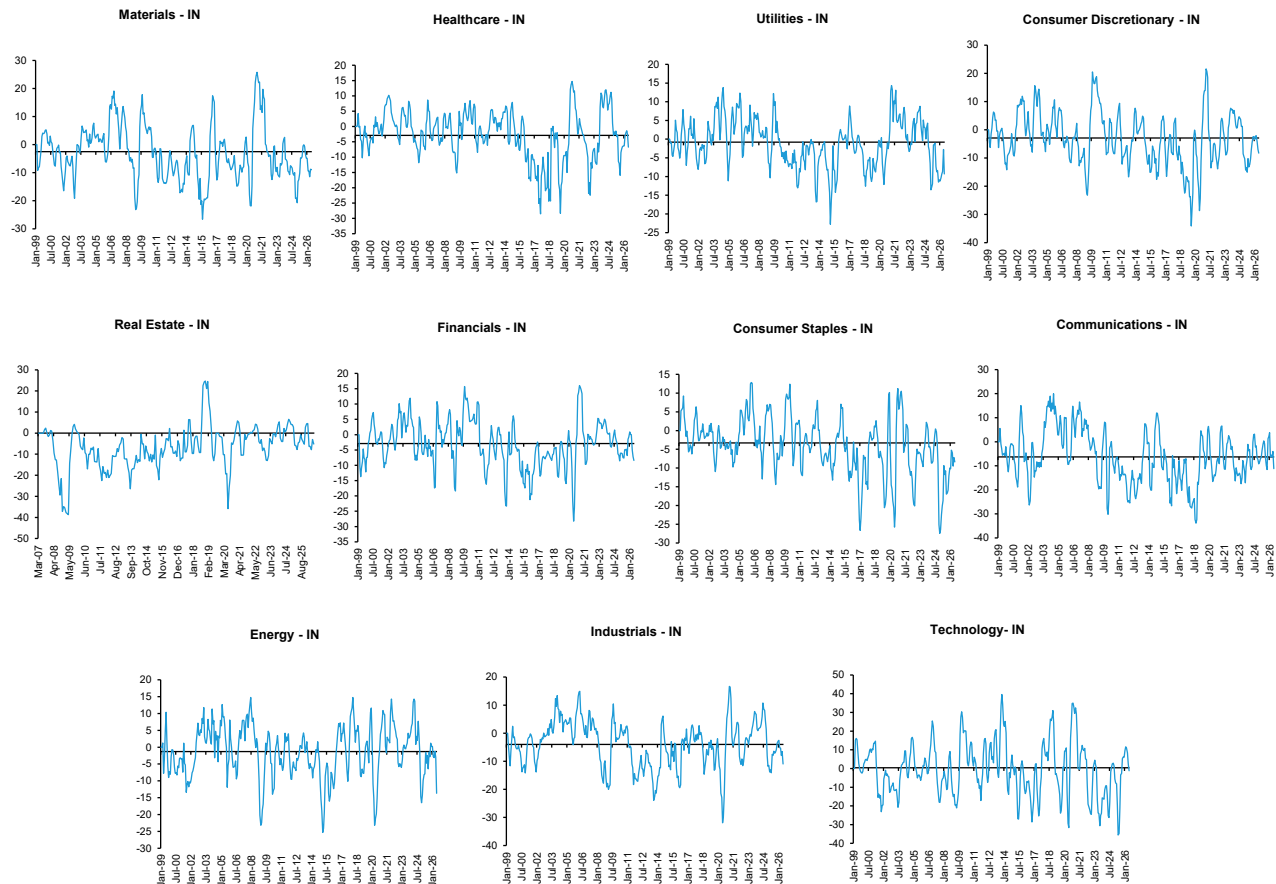
Disappointing earnings has been a key drag for Indian equities as an average stock continued to see higher pace of downgrades. Unfortunately, the downgrade cycle for India is still not showing a clear bottom; however the large-caps seem to be getting back some earnings support. India is seeing a broad-based earnings down cycle visible across all sectors except Materials and Consumer ex Autos which is showing some earnings recovery. In terms of crowding, we see extreme dispersion in investor interest - Energy, Staples, Tech, Real Estate are at record low crowding while large Utilities and average Financial stock looks crowded. (Exhibit 4-Exhibit 7) Hence, India is showing early signs of recovery led by large-caps and certain sectors like Materials, consumer while some sectors look attractive on valuations (Financials/Tech) or record low crowding (Staples/Tech/ Energy/Real Estate). We believe the opportunity set for investors in Indian markets is incrementally becoming more attractive.

EXHIBIT 4: India large-caps showing early signs of returning back to upgrades, however an average stock is still seeing increased pace of downward revisions



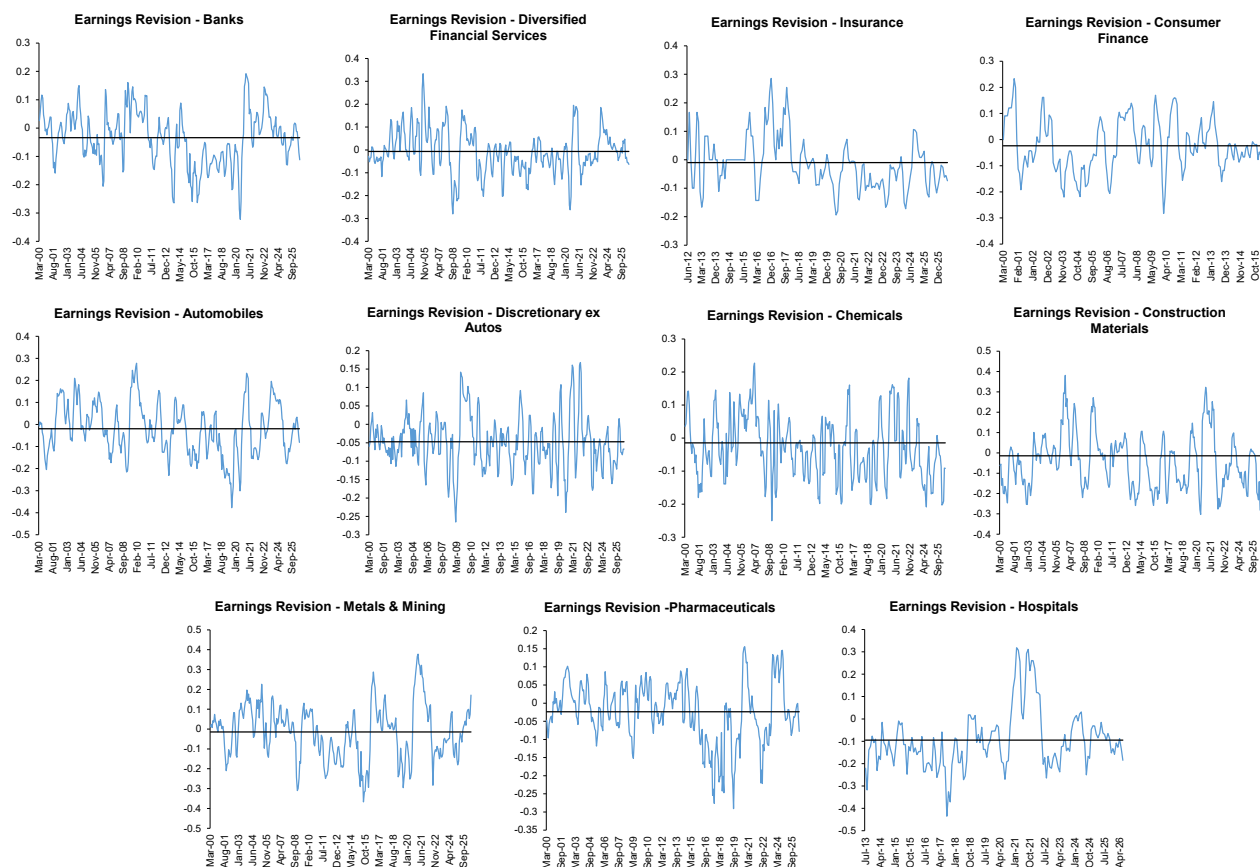
Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 5: Only Materials is showing earnings recovery. All sectors in downgrades

3mma of earnings revisions for FY1 and FY2 estimates. The charts shows number of upgrades-downgrades as % of total estimates. Data as of Jun 30th 2026
 Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

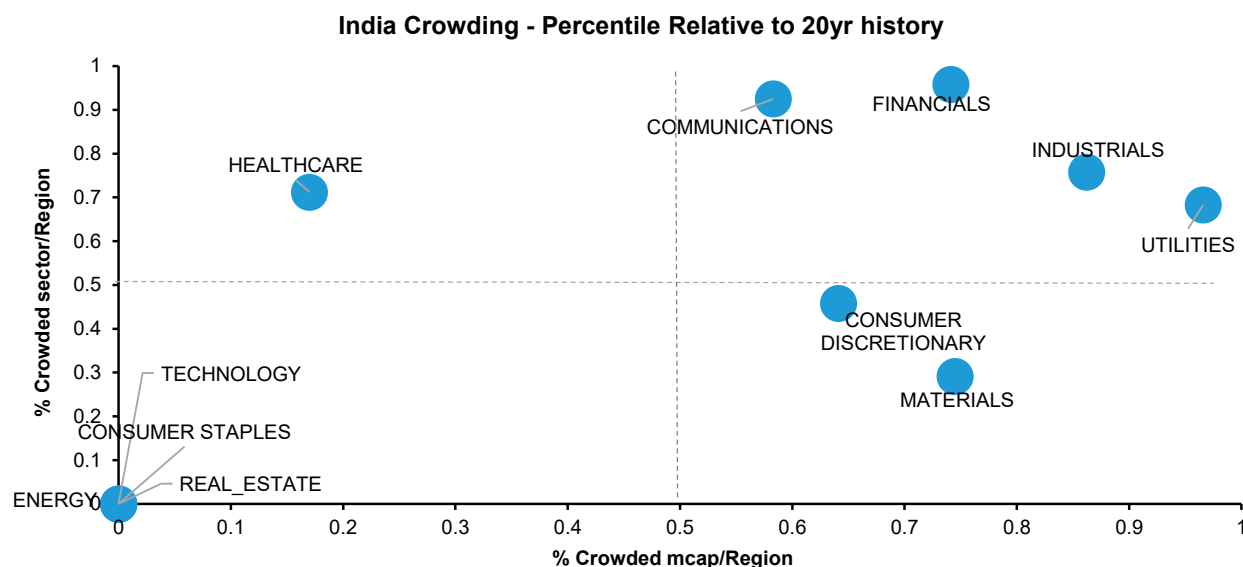
EXHIBIT 6: Discretionary ex-Autos, Metals & Mining, Chemicals in upward trending revisions. Construction Materials downgrade at record low (likely to bottom)



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 7: Extreme dispersion- Energy, Staples, Tech, Real Estate at record low crowding while large Utilities and average Financial stock crowded



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

LOW LONG-TERM EARNINGS EXPECTATIONS=POSITIVE RETURN OUTLOOK FOR NEXT 12MONTHS

The long-term earnings growth expectations for India again edged down from recent peak of 12.9% as of Jan 2026 to 10.6% as of Jun 2026 ie. below long-term average. Historically, low long-term growth expectations have resulted in positive next 12month fwd. returns for market. Using historical trends, while it is difficult to call the magnitude of next 12m returns, directionally, we are most likely headed towards positive returns over the next 12m. (Exhibit 8). From a market-structure perspective, the average stock dispersion in India is still making it difficult for active managers to pick stocks. However, above average dispersion in Utilities, Real Estate, Tech and Materials is presenting some active stock picking opportunities. (Exhibit 9-Exhibit 10)

EXHIBIT 8: The below average long-term earnings growth expectations sets a good backdrop for positive market returns over the next 12 months



For returns data, MSCI India Net Total Return USD Index is used. Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: Dispersion in India is just at historical average, creating challenging backdrop for active stock-picking

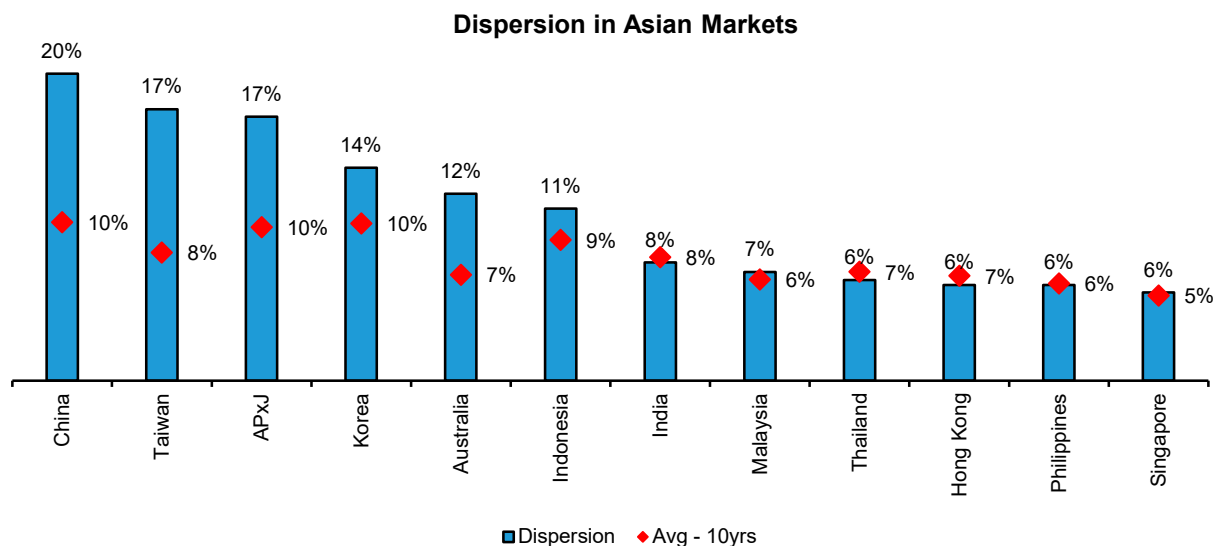
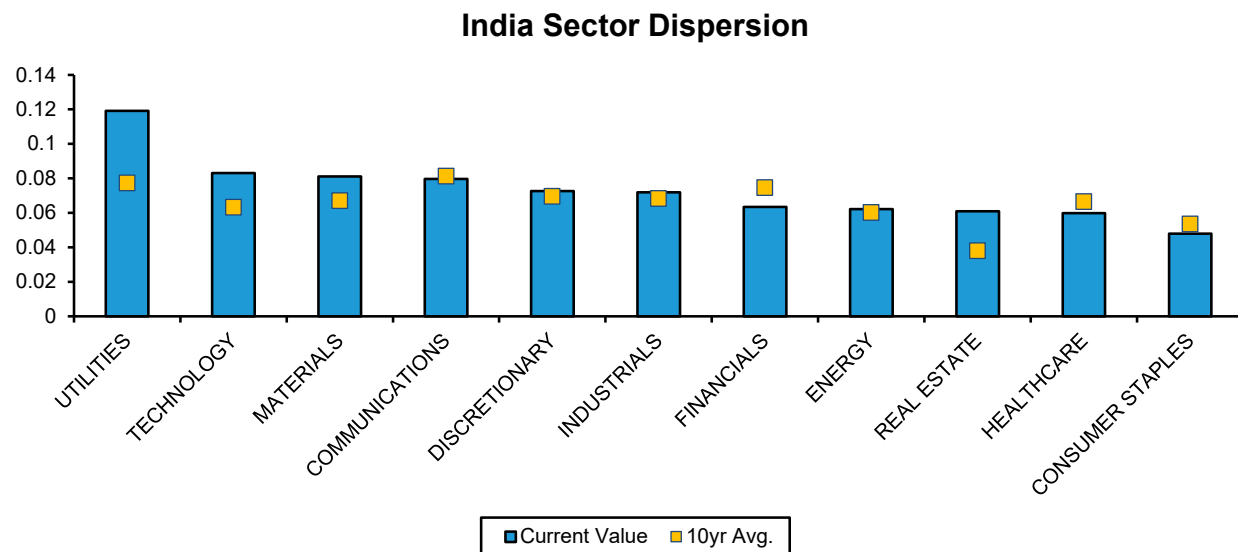


Exhibit above shows standard deviation of monthly return of all the stocks in MSCI index. Current dispersion is as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 10: However, within India, Utilities, Real Estate, Tech and Materials are showing above average dispersion, presenting some active stock picking opportunities



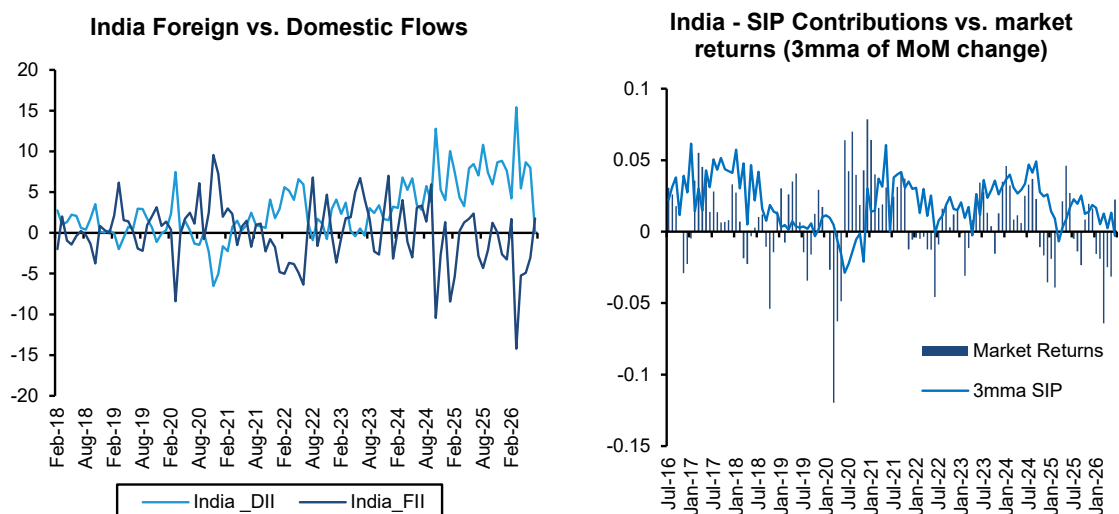
Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

FII SENTIMENT IMPROVING

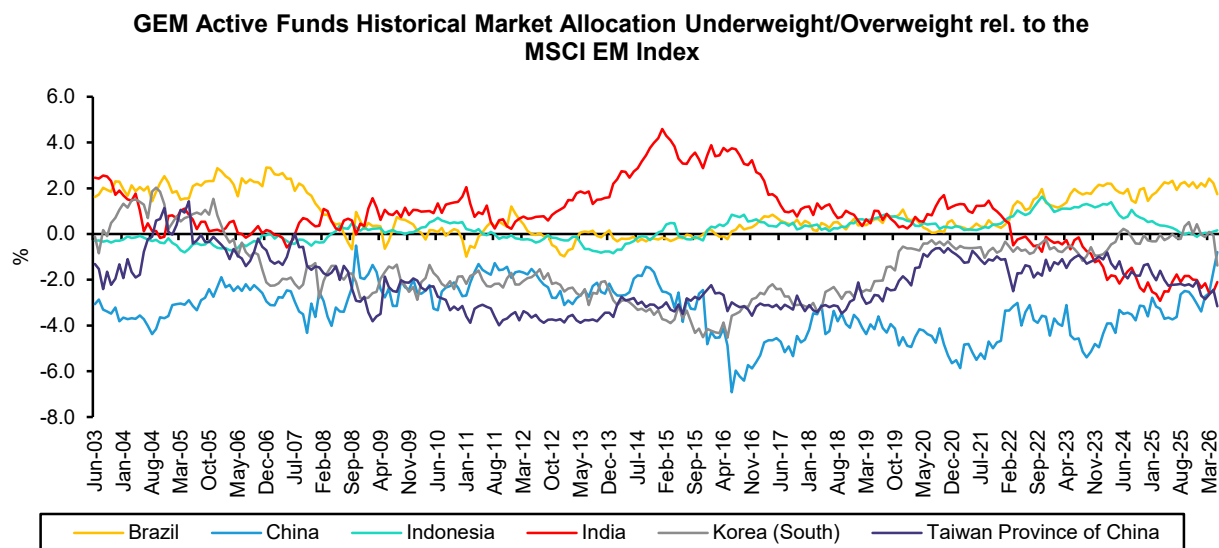
In 1H 2026, India market continued to see strong domestic institutional fund at US\$49bn which was +19% higher than US \$40bn seen in 1H 2025. However, FIIs pulled out record -US\$29bn which was much larger than the -US\$8bn in first half of previous year. Since June, FII outflow has been slowing down and MTD in July, there has been net inflow of +1.8bn USD while DII inflow has been slowing down. SIP 3m trend wise showed some improvement in May but again slowed down, not giving any positive signal. While India was the funding source for the AI/tech trade in the region, since June as AI/tech has seen more volatility, India seem to be getting back some foreign investor interest - we believe this is likely to increase further. Even GEM active funds have reduced their UW on India to -2.1% by May, up from -2.7% as of Feb. (Exhibit 11-Exhibit 12)

EXHIBIT 11: After -29bn USD of FII outflow, FII outflow slowed down in June and became net positive MTD in July (+\$1.8bn USD). DII flow is now slowing down. However, SIP 3mma trends are slowing down



Data as of Jul 15th 2026. SIP data as of Jun 30th 2026
Source: AMFI, Bloomberg, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 12: GEM active funds: The UW on India reached -2.7% as of Feb but reduced to -2.1% by May



Data till May 2026
Source: EPFR, Bernstein analysis

FACTOR OUTLOOK - PREFER LARGE-CAPS OVER SMIDS, ADD MOMENTUM+MAINTAIN DEFENSIVE EXPOSURE

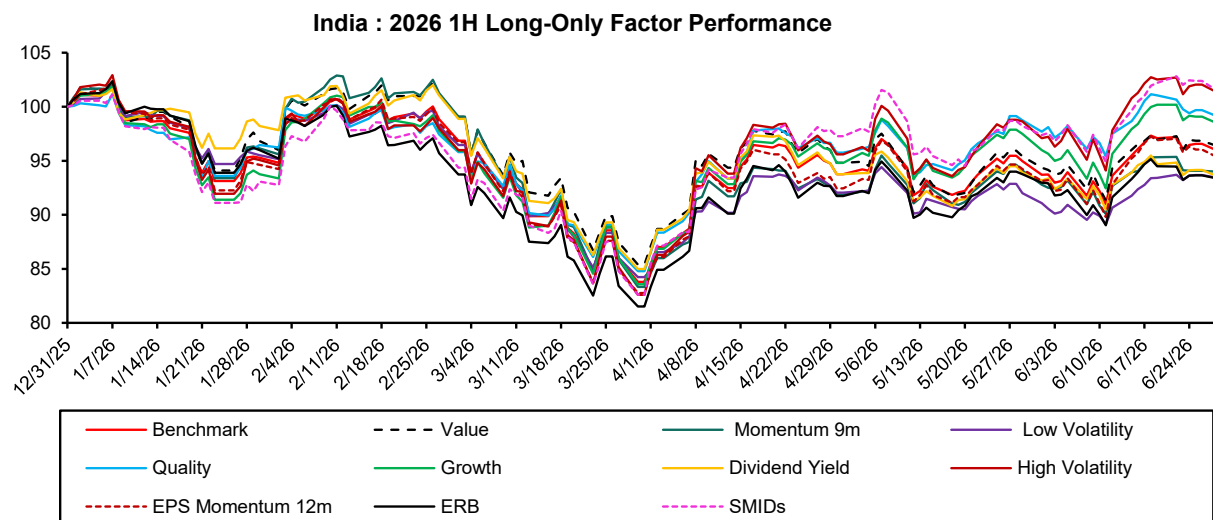
Since April 2026, we added back some risk in India through momentum exposure while recommended to still have some defensive exposure. We maintain this barbell, and we believe the momentum uptick that started since April (up 15%) is likely to strengthen from here. However, given the geopolitical and earnings uncertainty we still maintain some defensive exposure. However, we focus on companies where earnings momentum has been improving.

In 1H26, India quality/high vol (-0.8%) has been most resilient, while low vol (-7.2%) has underperformed most vs. market (-4.5%). FYOFY3 Growth (-1.6%) and momentum (-4.0%) also did better than market. However, we note that since April, factors in India market started coming back – high vol/SMIDs(+20%), FYOFY3 growth (+18%), quality (+17%) and momentum (+15%) have been outperforming the market (+14%). (Exhibit 13)

We started 2026 with all styles stretched on valuation, except momentum which was trading closer to 10-year average. In first half of 2026, all factors have gradually de-rated. Now, only high FCF yield and quality remain relatively expensive, near +1SD above the 10-year average while Price momentum and large caps are the cheapest, trading at -1SD below the 10-year average. Relative to market also, momentum and large-caps are the cheapest, trading at -1SD level, while quality/value/SMIDs are still expensive.

Looking at earnings revisions for factors, we note that by 2Q26, all factors have been in net downgrades, except momentum which remains in upgrades. Only momentum and quality are seeing early signs of earnings recovery while all other factors are still seeing increased pace of downgrades. On relative-basis, except mid-caps/high vol/value, all other styles are showing better than market earnings revisions. (Exhibit 14-Exhibit 16) Overall, momentum, large-caps and quality look most consistent where relative valuation and earnings advantage looks strong. We show our preferred buy list of momentum stocks and quality stocks in Exhibit 17- Exhibit 18

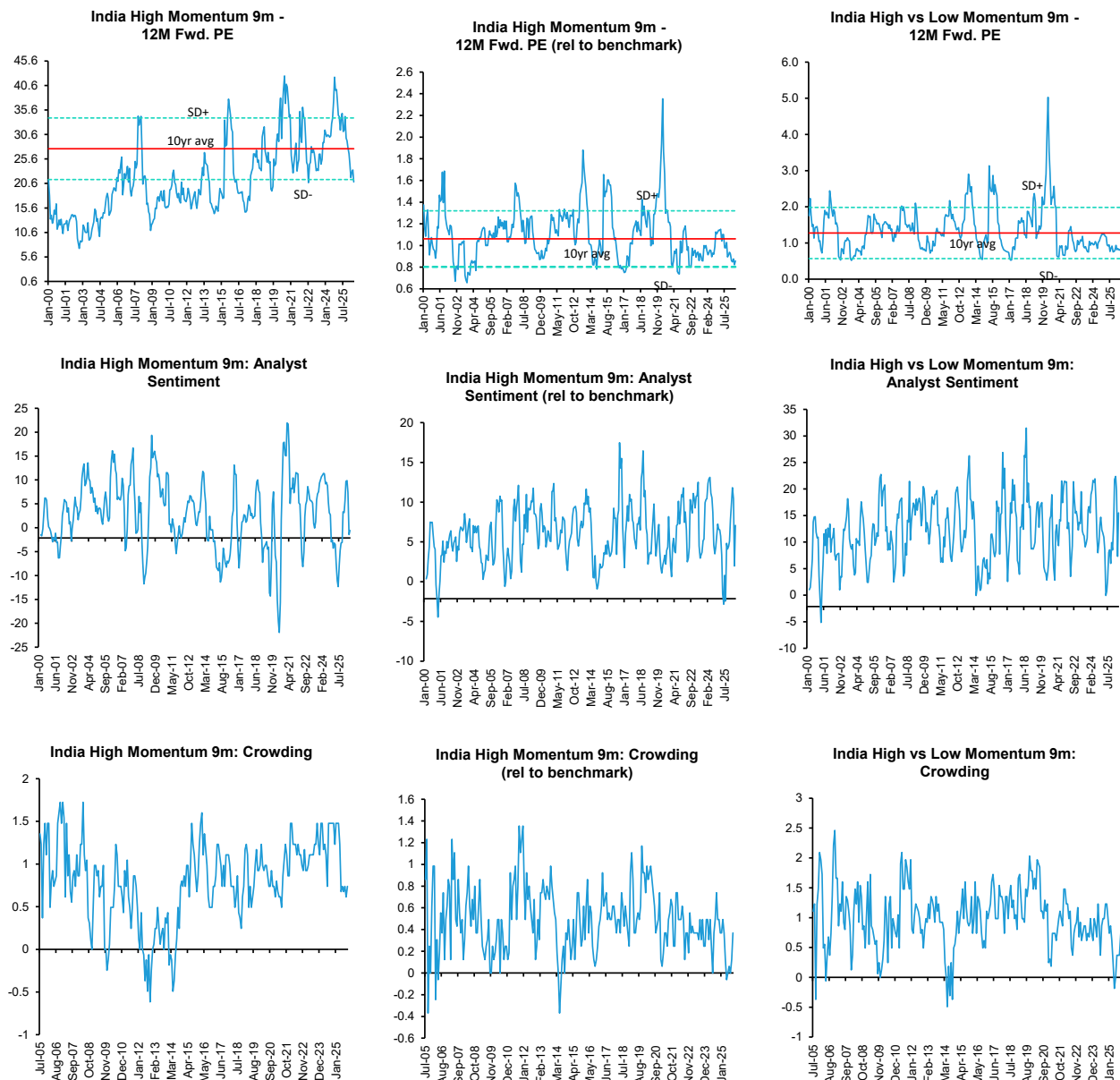
EXHIBIT 13: In 1H26, India Quality/High vol (-0.8%) has been most resilient while Low vol (-7.2%) has underperformed most vs. market (-4.5%). Since April, factors rebounded sharply –high vol/SMIDs(+20%), growth (+18%), quality (+17%), momentum (+15%) have been outperforming the market (+14%)



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

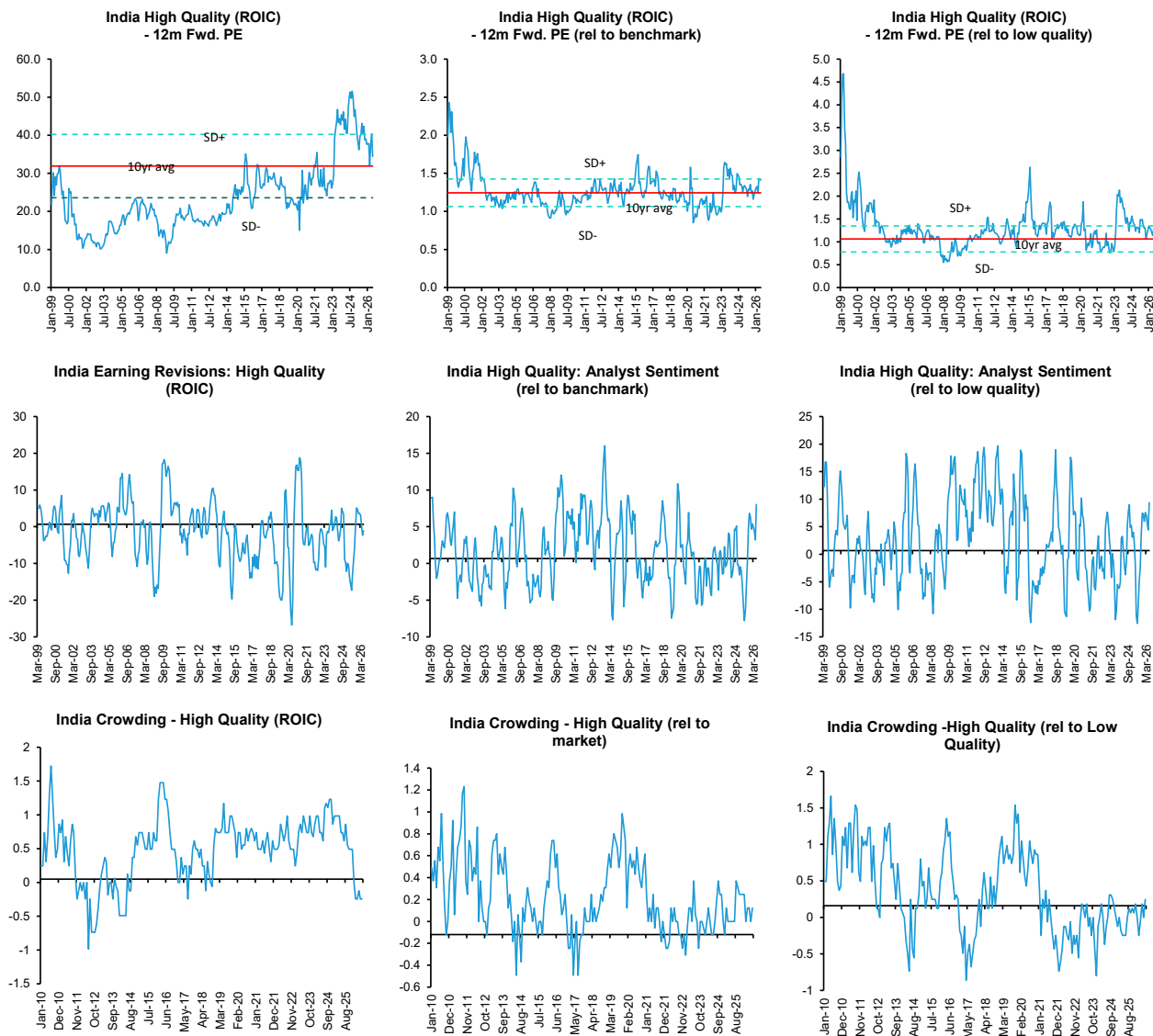
EXHIBIT 14: India Momentum: Valuations have come down to attractive level, around -1SD on both absolute and relative basis. Earnings support is strong on relative basis while crowding is inflecting. We expect India momentum to keep building up from here



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

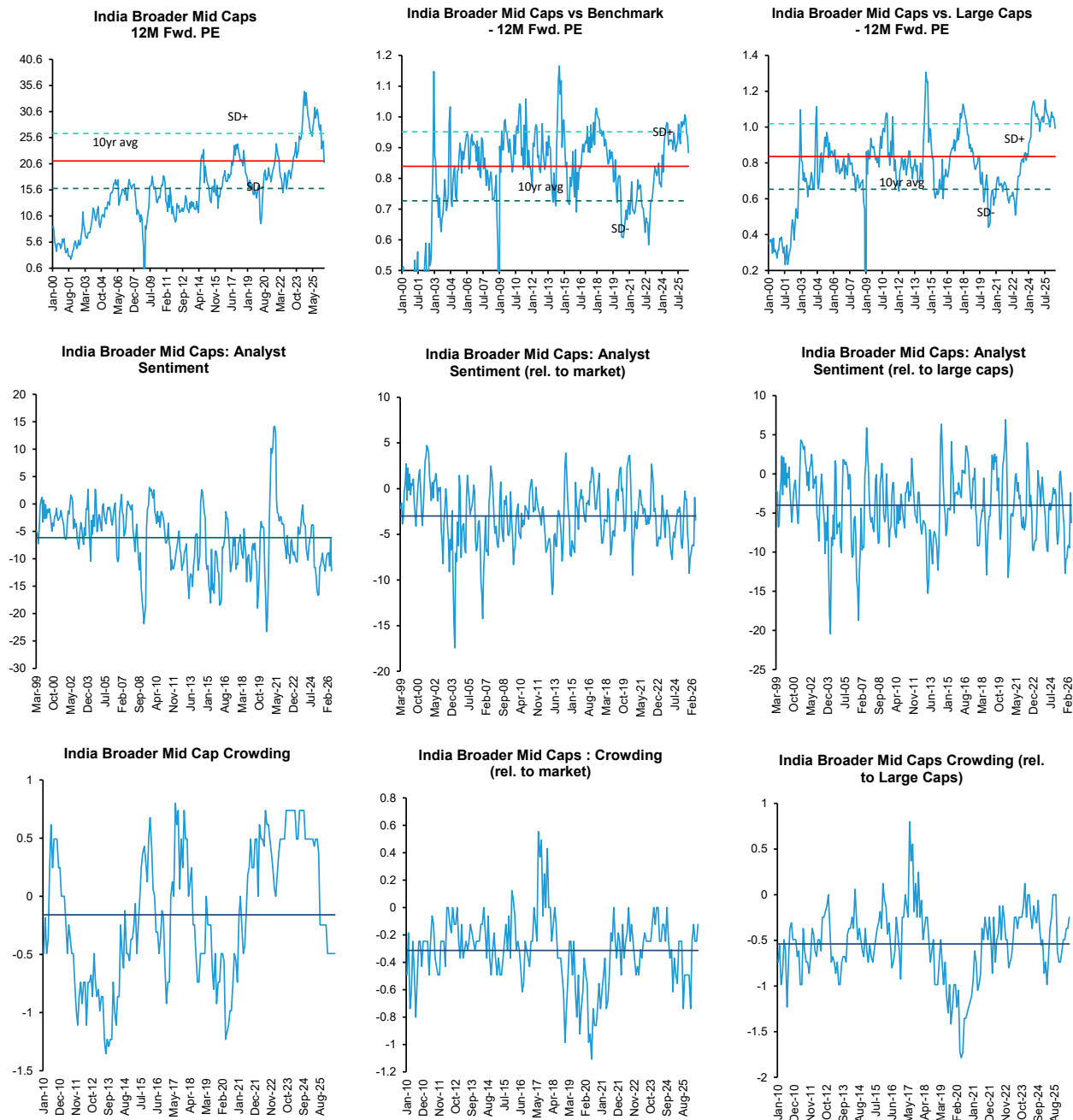
EXHIBIT 15: India High Quality: Quality comes at a price but earnings support is still intact. Given geopolitical uncertainty and lack of broad-earnings support, we believe sticking to some defensive exposure is prudent



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 16: There has been a clear valuation downcycle for SMIDs on an absolute and relative basis along with earning downgrades. We believe India large-caps are better positioned in the near term



Data as of Jun 30th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 17: **India momentum buy-list: Chase momentum (where earnings are improving)**

SECTOR	COMPANY	SEDOL	12m Fwd. PE	10yr PE Zscore	6m EPS Momentum	12m EPS Momentum	Total Institutional Ownership Ranking vs 3yr diff. (as of Mar'26)	Bernstein rating
CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	BAJAJ AUTO	B2QKXW	22x	0.2	13%	9%	8	O
CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	TITAN COMPANY	613934	53x	-0.7	24%	19%	4	O
FINANCIALS	AXIS BANK	BPFIHC	12x	-1.2	20%	1%	6	O
FINANCIALS	INDUSIND BANK	610045	14x	-0.4	137%	-34%	9	O
HEALTHCARE	SUN PHARMACEUTICAL IND	658248	29x	0.3	7%	-5%	6	O
HEALTHCARE	ZYDUS LIFESCIENCES	BYM8TG	24x	0.6	-12%	-16%	7	O
INDUSTRIALS	ADANI PORTS AND SEZ	B28XXH	24x	0.8	5%	4%	6	O
INDUSTRIALS	LARSEN & TOUBRO	B0166K	24x	0.1	9%	3%	9	O
FINANCIALS	STATE BANK OF INDIA	B5QCB2	10x	-0.6	4%	3%	7	M
HEALTHCARE	AUROBINDO PHARMA	670263	18x	1.1	18%	0%	8	M
CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	BHARAT FORGE	B0C1DM	47x	0.5	33%	17%	5	
CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	FSN ECOMMERCE VENTURES	BP4DCB	122x	-3.8	117%	82%	1	
CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	SAMVARDHANA MOTHERSON	674399	24x	-0.3	29%	-29%	6	
CONSUMER STAPLES	MARICO	B1S34K	45x	0.0	13%	5%	6	
CONSUMER STAPLES	NESTLE INDIA	BQ88GH	61x	-0.2	16%	-48%	7	
CONSUMER STAPLES	VARUN BEVERAGES	BQ880M	43x	-0.4	10%	-2%	3	
ENERGY	COAL INDIA	B4Z9XF	8x	-0.2	0%	-15%	8	
FINANCIALS	ADITYA BIRLA CAPITAL	BYVKT1	19x	0.1	22%	14%	3	
FINANCIALS	AU SMALL FINANCE BANK	BF1YBK	18x	-2.4	31%	19%	2	
FINANCIALS	IDFC FIRST BANK	BYWZNK	13x	-0.4	46%	7%	1	
FINANCIALS	L AND T FINANCE	B5KYHQ	17x	0.7	17%	13%	2	
FINANCIALS	SHRIRAM FINANCE	B54DBX	15x	1.3	9%	1%	9	
FINANCIALS	UNION BANK OF INDIA	657963	7x	-0.2	3%	-3%	3	
HEALTHCARE	APOLLO HOSPITALS	627358	42x	-0.2	23%	18%	8	
HEALTHCARE	DIVI'S LABORATORIES	660251	48x	0.5	12%	2%	5	
INDUSTRIALS	ABB INDIA	B1Y9QS	71x	0.4	0%	-17%	9	
INDUSTRIALS	ADANI ENTERPRISES	B01VRK	54x	0.0	4%	-24%	9	
INDUSTRIALS	ASHOK LEYLAND	B01NFT	20x	-0.2	6%	-46%	5	
INDUSTRIALS	BHARAT HEAVY ELECTRICALS	B6SNRV	34x	-0.3	60%	32%	8	
INDUSTRIALS	CG POWER & INDUSTRIAL	B1B90H	72x	0.2	20%	5%	4	
INDUSTRIALS	SIEMENS INDIA	B15T56	54x	0.0	0%	-2%	9	
MATERIALS	ASIAN PAINTS	BCRWL6	46x	-1.0	4%	0%	2	
MATERIALS	GRASIM INDUSTRIES	BYQKH3	110x	0.4	465%	371%	7	
MATERIALS	SOLAR INDUSTRIES INDIA	BYZ9NH	56x	-1.0	35%	27%	2	
MATERIALS	TATA STEEL	BPQWCZ	11x	-0.2	46%	31%	4	
REAL ESTATE	PHOENIX MILLS	B0SXY9	39x	-1.1	11%	5%	5	
TECHNOLOGY	ORACLE FINL SVCS SOFTW	652844	28x	1.2	23%	14%	4	
TELECOM	INDUS TOWERS	B92P9G	13x	-0.5	4%	-1%	1	
TELECOM	TATA COMMUNICATIONS	611474	26x	-0.6	24%	-5%	0	
UTILITIES	TORRENT POWER	B1JLL3	22x	0.8	-2%	-8%	4	

Data as of Jun 30th 2026. Analyst Ratings: O= Outperform, M=Market-Perform (Bernstein Brand)/N=Neutral (Autonomous Brand), U = Underperform rating. Further details of the research and important disclosures of the above covered securities are available on the Bernstein Research website: <https://bernsteinautonomous.bluematrix.com/sellside/Disclosures.action>.

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 18: **India defensive exposure: Keep defensive tilt through high quality where earnings have inflected**

SEDOL	Sector	Company	12m Fwd. PE	10yr PE zscore	Total Institutional Ownership Ranking vs 3yr diff. (as of Mar'26)	6m EPS Momentum	12m EPS Momentum	Bernstein Rating
BMW4CV	CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	EICHER MOTORS	27x	-0.5	6	11%	11%	M
632732	CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	HERO MOTOCORP	15x	-0.8	5	7%	3%	M
BD87BS	CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	CROMPTON GREAVES CON ELE	24x	-2.0	4	10%	-14%	
BR4TRD	CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	HYUNDAI MOTOR INDIA	22x	-2.5	0	-11%	-11%	
BPG9V3	CONSUMER DISCRETIONARY	SCHAEFFLER INDIA	42x	-1.8	10	13%	7%	
BGSQG4	CONSUMER STAPLES	BRITANNIA INDUSTRIES	41x	-1.6	5	4%	0%	
674103	CONSUMER STAPLES	EMAMI	20x	-1.4	9	-5%	-17%	
626167	CONSUMER STAPLES	HINDUSTAN UNILEVER	40x	-2.0	7	2%	-5%	
B0JGGP	CONSUMER STAPLES	ITC	17x	-1.3	3	-11%	-20%	
B1S34K	CONSUMER STAPLES	MARICO	45x	0.0	6	13%	5%	
BQB8GH	CONSUMER STAPLES	NESTLE INDIA	61x	-0.2	7	16%	-48%	
660251	HEALTHCARE	DIVI'S LABORATORIES	48x	0.5	5	12%	2%	
BF1THH	INDUSTRIALS	BHARAT ELECTRONICS	37x	1.0	10	11%	9%	
BQGZWP	INDUSTRIALS	HAVELLS INDIA	35x	-1.7	7	10%	-8%	
BR56KD	INDUSTRIALS	HINDUSTAN AERONAUTICS	27x	0.2	8	8%	1%	
BL6C48	INDUSTRIALS	INDIAN RAIL CATER & TOUR	23x	-2.1	4	4%	-3%	
613590	INDUSTRIALS	INGERSOLL-RAND INDIA	39x	-1.4		-19%	-32%	
BS6Y1L	INDUSTRIALS	MAZAGON DOCK SHIPBUILDER	32x	-4.1	3	-4%	0%	
BCRWL6	MATERIALS	ASIAN PAINTS	46x	-1.0	2	4%	0%	
BKS8B7	MATERIALS	CASTROL INDIA	16x	-0.7	9	-5%	-12%	
618069	MATERIALS	LINDE INDIA	86x	0.1	9	9%	-11%	

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Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

We acknowledge the contributions of Rui Shi towards creation of this report.

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

I. REQUIRED DISCLOSURES

References to "Bernstein" or the "Firm" in these disclosures relate to the following entities: Bernstein Institutional Services LLC (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein & Co., LLC (pre April 1, 2024), Bernstein Autonomous LLP, BSG France S.A. (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein (Hong Kong) Limited 盛博香港有限公司, Sanford C. Bernstein (Canada) Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein (India) Private Limited (SEBI registration no. INH000006378), Sanford C. Bernstein (Singapore) Private Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein Japan KK (サンフォード・C・バーンスタイン株式会社) and analysts employed by Société Générale Africa Technologies & Services to produce Bernstein research under a Global Services Agreement in place between Bernstein and Société Générale.

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The Bernstein brand rates stocks based on forecasts of relative performance for the next 12 months versus the S&P 500 for stocks listed on the U.S. and Canadian exchanges, versus the Bloomberg Europe Developed Markets Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index EUR (EDME) for stocks listed on the European exchanges and emerging markets exchanges outside of the Asia Pacific region, versus the Bloomberg Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index USD (JPL) for stocks listed on the Japanese exchanges, and versus the Bloomberg Asia ex-Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index (ASIA) for stocks listed on the Asian (ex-Japan) exchanges -unless otherwise specified.

The Bernstein brand has three categories of ratings:

- Outperform: Stock will outpace the market index by more than 15 pp
- Market-Perform: Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/- 15 pp
- Underperform: Stock will trail the performance of the market index by more than 15 pp

Coverage Suspended: Coverage of a company under the Bernstein research brand has been suspended. Ratings and price targets are suspended temporarily, are no longer current, and should therefore not be relied upon.

Not Rated: A rating assigned when the stock cannot be accurately valued, or the performance of the company accurately predicted, at the present time. The covering analyst may continue to publish research reports on the company to update investors on events and developments.

Not Covered (NC) denotes companies that are not under coverage.

Bernstein brand stock ratings are based on a 12-month time horizon.

Autonomous brand – common stocks

The Autonomous brand rates common stocks as indicated below. As our benchmarks we use the Bloomberg Europe 600 Financials Price Return Index (E600BK) and Bloomberg Europe Dev Mkt Financials Large and Mid Cap Price Ret Index EUR (EDMFI) index for developed European banks and Payments, the Bloomberg Europe 600 Insurance Price Return Index (E600IN) for European insurers, the S&P 500 and S&P Financials for US banks and Payments coverage, S5LIFE for US Insurance, the S&P Insurance Select Industry (SPSIINS) for US Non-Life Insurers coverage, and the Bloomberg Emerging Markets Financials Large, Mid and Small Cap Price Return Index (EMLS) for emerging market banks and insurers and Payments. Ratings are stated relative to the sector (not the market).

The Autonomous brand has three categories of common stock ratings:

- Outperform (OP): Stock will outpace the relevant index by more than 10 pp

- Neutral (N): Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/-10 pp
- Underperform (UP): Stock will trail the performance of the relevant index by more than 10 pp

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